Emmanuel Macron

Hello everyone, and welcome to this fifth episode of the Cottongue Podcast.

[00:00:12] I hope you're well and ready to listen to something in French. I'm very happy because there are more and more listeners. A "listener" is a person who listens to a radio programme or a podcast. So if you listen to the Cottongue Podcast, you're a listener — in French, un auditeur, or une auditrice if you're a woman.

[00:00:44] In short, it's really wonderful to know that so many people are listening to me. I hope it makes you want to do a little French every day. You know that regularity is the most important thing when learning a language. Learning a language is a little like going to the gym. There's no point in going to the gym once a month, even if you stay there all day. If you don't exercise for a month and then exercise for an entire day, you'll be very tired and won't make any progress. To progress, to improve, you need to practise regularly, every day if possible.

[00:01:46] Why? Because when we do something regularly, it becomes a habit. And when this activity becomes a habit, we no longer question it. We don't ask ourselves, "Do I have time to do this today?" We don't say to ourselves, "Oh no, I'm tired today, so I'll do it another day." If it's a habit, we do it every day.

[00:02:21] And for French to become a daily habit, an everyday habit, the best solution is to do things you enjoy! If you like watching videos on YouTube, watch videos by French YouTubers. If you like a particular style of music, look for French bands on Spotify, for example. In fact, I've posted an article on my blog with recommendations of French artists. There's something for every taste: rock, pop, electronic music, rap. Go and read this article, and I'm sure you'll find an artist or a band that appeals to you, that you'll like. My blog address is cottongue.com/blog [this website no longer exists, but I've made a "French Music" playlist on YouTube].

[00:03:33] You probably know this, but in France there was a very important election two weeks ago: the presidential election.

[00:03:45] Why is the presidential election so important in France? Because the President, the President of the Republic as he's called, has a lot of power. For example, he appoints, chooses, the Prime Minister. He also plays a major role in diplomacy. He represents France abroad, in relations with other countries. He is also the head of the armed forces, in other words the military forces, and can even decide to use nuclear weapons, the atomic bomb.

[00:04:36] Besides all these powers, the President of the Republic has a great deal of legitimacy. That means his authority is recognised and accepted by French people. The President is legitimate because he's elected by French people through direct universal suffrage. Direct universal suffrage is an electoral system in which all citizens vote directly for the candidate they've chosen. So in France, all French people vote directly for the candidate they want to elect President. This system differs from the American system, for example, because Americans vote for "electors" rather than directly for a candidate.

[00:05:45] The presidential election also receives a great deal of media coverage. A year before the election begins, all the media are already talking about it every day. And during the presidential campaign, when candidates conduct their official campaigns to persuade French people, the media talk about nothing but the election. Every day, on television, on the radio and on the internet, the media talk only about the election. So of course French people also talk about nothing else, only the election, all day, at work, with their family or friends. People ask others which candidate they'll vote for and discuss the different programmes, and the scandals too! Perhaps you heard that during the last election, there were several financial scandals involving certain candidates. But we're not going to talk about that today.

[00:07:05] In short, for all these reasons, you can understand that the presidential election is the most important election in France.

[00:07:16] The people entitled to vote are French citizens who are adults, meaning citizens aged eighteen or over. There are two rounds in this election. In the first round, voters can choose from all the official candidates. This year's election had eleven candidates. Then the two candidates with the highest scores go through to the second round, unless one candidate receives more than 50% of the votes. If a candidate receives more than 50% of the votes in the first round, that candidate is directly elected President of the Republic, without a second round. But that has never yet happened in history. A second round has always been necessary. In the second round, of course, the candidate who receives the most votes wins the election.

[00:08:35] This year, as you know, Mr Emmanuel Macron won the presidential election with 66% of the votes against Ms Marine Le Pen, the candidate of the far-right party. Emmanuel Macron was therefore elected to be President of France for five years. Five years is the length of the presidential term in France, the period during which the President is in power.

[00:09:14] So today, we're going to talk about Emmanuel Macron. He's a President of the Republic who is quite different from previous presidents, because he's very young, only thirty-nine years old! But also because he was completely unknown four years ago. Four years ago, nobody knew who Emmanuel Macron was. He was an unknown person. But he managed to become famous very quickly, to create his own political party, called "En marche!", and to win the presidential election in France.

[00:10:02] We're going to see how such a young and unknown man managed to become President of the Republic so quickly.

[00:10:14] Are you ready? Then here we go!

[00:10:22] Emmanuel Macron was born in 1977 in Amiens. Amiens is a city in northern France with 150,000 inhabitants. He comes from a well-off family. "Well-off" means "having money", someone for whom money isn't a problem. Emmanuel Macron's family was well-off because both his parents were doctors, so you can imagine there were no money problems in the Macron household.

[00:11:08] At twelve, young Emmanuel converted to the Catholic religion, meaning he was baptised and became Catholic. For him, Catholicism was a personal choice and a way to

develop his spirituality. In fact, he would attend a Catholic middle school. Middle school is the school pupils in France attend between twelve and sixteen, before high school. So Emmanuel Macron studied at a private Catholic middle school.

[00:11:58] During his studies, Emmanuel was a brilliant pupil, a model pupil. He always had excellent marks, excellent results.

[00:12:11] At fifteen, Emmanuel had a very important encounter. He took part in his middle school's drama club and met Brigitte Trogneux, the French teacher in charge of this drama club. This teacher was very impressed by young Emmanuel's intelligence. They were both passionate about literature. They quickly fell in love. You know, in French we say "tomber amoureux", to fall in love, when we begin to feel love for someone. We use the verb "to fall" because it's something we don't control, like when we fall, when we lose our balance.

[00:13:09] But many people were shocked by this relationship because Brigitte Trogneux was thirty-seven when she met Emmanuel. She was married and had three children. So Emmanuel's parents decided to send him to a high school in Paris so he would no longer see his teacher, so he would stop seeing, spending time with, Brigitte.

[00:13:44] So Emmanuel arrived at the high school, at Lycée Henri-IV in Paris, which is one of the best high schools in France. He obtained his science baccalaureate with the distinction "very good". The baccalaureate is the examination pupils have to take at the end of high school, after their final year. Generally, it's simply called the "bac", because "baccalauréat" is a little too long! The distinction "very good" means he had excellent marks in this examination.

[00:14:27] After high school, Emmanuel began studying literature and social sciences. He obtained a master's degree in philosophy with a thesis on Machiavelli. He also studied political science and entered the prestigious École nationale d'administration, ENA. This is a school that trains people for the highest positions in public administration. The majority of French presidents have attended this school. Sometimes people say ENA is the school of presidents.

[00:15:20] During his studies, Emmanuel reunited with Brigitte, who had left her husband. In 2007, when Emmanuel Macron was thirty, he married Brigitte.

[00:15:39] Now we're going to talk a little about Emmanuel Macron's career.

[00:15:45] When he finished at the École nationale d'administration, he began working at the Inspection générale des finances, the General Inspectorate of Finance. This institution is responsible for checking the budgets of public administration.

[00:16:05] But in 2008, he decided to leave the public sector and go to work in the private sector. Working in the private sector means working for a private company. Which company do you think he decided to work for? Do you have any idea?

[00:16:34] In 2008, Emmanuel Macron joined the famous investment bank Rothschild. He stayed at this bank for four years and earned a lot of money, more than two million euros. So he became a millionaire. Later, he would be strongly criticised for his time at this bank. Some

people say he wants to help banks earn even more money.

[00:17:09] But in 2012, Emmanuel Macron resumed his political career. 2012 was the year of the victory of François Hollande, the Socialist candidate who became the new French President. Because Emmanuel Macron was close to Hollande, he became his secretary-general. This is a very important position because the secretary-general is the person closest to the President, his adviser. It's a little like a vice-president, because there is no vice-president in France.

[00:17:57] Two years later, in 2014, Emmanuel became Minister of the Economy, once again a very important position. He decided to liberalise the French economy, for example by allowing businesses to operate on Sundays. This is interesting for understanding Macron's political ideas. His personal values are rather left-wing, on the side of the Socialists, but on the economy he is very economically liberal, so rather right-wing.

[00:18:41] As you've understood, Emmanuel Macron doesn't like staying in the same place too long. His career developed very quickly. He managed to obtain important positions while still very young, and that is rather unusual in France. In France, politicians are generally older than in other countries. If you want to obtain a good position as a member of parliament or a senator, you need to wait your turn! You need to wait for others to leave before taking their place. But Emmanuel Macron wasn't patient enough to wait his turn. He wanted his place straight away, immediately.

[00:19:43] That's why in 2016, he left his position as Minister of the Economy and created his own political movement, called "En marche!" This expression comes from the verb "marcher", to walk, and means that we need to move forward. Emmanuel Macron thinks France is stuck, that it's standing still, and he wants to move it forward.

[00:20:16] So we understand that with this political movement, Macron wanted to stand in the presidential election.

[00:20:31] At first, everyone thought his strategy wouldn't work, that it wouldn't function. Macron was fairly unknown to French people. They didn't really know who he was. The media talked a little about him when he was Minister of the Economy, but many French people didn't even know his name!

[00:21:00] In France, there are two main political parties: the Socialist Party on the left and Les Républicains on the right. The President is almost always the candidate of one of these two parties. But Macron's strategy was different because when he created his political movement, Emmanuel Macron declared that it was neither right-wing nor left-wing. In fact, the En Marche! movement is rather between the left and the right. It is at the centre of the political scene.

[00:21:51] To build his presidential programme, he chose a fairly innovative, fairly new solution. He decided to question French people directly, to ask what their problems were, what things they wanted to change. One hundred thousand French people were interviewed, and their answers were used to create a programme that would respond to their expectations, their demands. This was a strategy they copied from Barack Obama's

campaign in the United States. Usually, political parties write a programme without asking voters what they want. But Macron thought that to win, it was necessary to know exactly what French people wanted and to use the same words, the same phrases, to be understood clearly.

[00:23:08] But for a long time, Emmanuel Macron didn't reveal his programme. He didn't say what measures he wanted to adopt. That is also a good strategy because the other candidates couldn't really attack him. The only attack they could make was to say Macron had no programme.

[00:23:36] Macron was also criticised because he always said what people wanted to hear. He agreed with everyone and never opposed others. So people began to think he had no personal ideas, no convictions. People thought he wanted to please everyone simply to get elected, but had no clear vision for France.

[00:24:15] Some also thought Macron was too young, that he didn't have enough experience to become President of the Republic. What's more, Macron had never stood in an election before the presidential election. So he had never been elected by French people. The political positions he had previously obtained — the President's secretary-general and Minister of the Economy — he had obtained only thanks to François Hollande's help. And after receiving François Hollande's help, Macron decided to betray him by creating his own political party. The verb "to betray" means someone trusts you, and you take advantage of that trust to do something against them. François Hollande trusted Emmanuel Macron, but Emmanuel Macron didn't respect that trust and left the Government to create his own party. People who know Macron say he uses people to gain advantages. They say Macron is manipulative, that he manipulates people. In politics, unfortunately, things often happen like this. But Macron does it openly.

[00:26:08] Despite all this criticism, Macron won the first round of the presidential election. In the second round, he faced the far-right candidate Marine Le Pen. To prevent Marine Le Pen from winning, all the other political parties called on voters to vote for Emmanuel Macron. So in the second round, he won by a wide margin with 66% of the votes.

[00:26:53] Finally, we're going to look at the new French President's programme. First, unlike many other candidates, Emmanuel Macron is very much in favour of the European Union. He wants countries in the Union that wish to go further with the project to have the opportunity to do so. He proposes that countries belonging to the eurozone, in other words countries that have adopted the euro, should have their own budget, a parliament separate from the European Parliament, and a Minister of Finance.

[00:27:42] Regarding the economy, I told you the new French President is fairly economically liberal. For example, he wants to eliminate 120,000 civil-service positions. Civil servants are people who work for the state, for public administration. Emmanuel Macron's objective, his goal, is to reduce public expenditure by sixty billion euros over five years. So he wants the French state to be less indebted. He wants to reduce debt. In France, the legal working time is thirty-five hours a week. French people work thirty-five hours a week. But Emmanuel Macron has often criticised this working time, so perhaps French people will soon have to

work a little longer.

[00:28:52] Now, what are the next steps for the new President? What challenges await Emmanuel Macron?

[00:29:04] Even though the President has a lot of power in France, he cannot do everything! He needs a majority in Parliament for laws to be accepted. And the legislative elections to elect members of parliament will take place on 11 and 18 June. So if Emmanuel Macron wants to get his proposals accepted, candidates from his movement, La République en marche!, need to win the legislative elections to take seats in the Assembly, in Parliament.

[00:29:50] If there aren't enough members to have a majority in the Assembly, then alliances will have to be made with other parties in order to govern.

[00:30:05] So you see, not everything has been won yet for Emmanuel Macron.

[00:30:15] To conclude, there are three important things to remember, to memorise, about Emmanuel Macron.

[00:30:25] The first is that Emmanuel Macron is the youngest President in the history of the Fifth Republic. He's only thirty-nine. The second is that he created a new centrist party, a political party that is neither right-wing nor left-wing. And the third, concerning Emmanuel Macron's ideas, is that he's rather economically liberal and pro-European: he's in favour of the European Union.

[00:31:09] And I have a question for you: have the media in your country talked about Emmanuel Macron in your country? If so, what do the media say about Emmanuel Macron? What do they think of him? I'm very curious to know. It interests me a great deal! Send me an email at hugo@innerfrench.com to tell me. I'm eagerly awaiting your emails!

[00:31:46] We're coming to the end of this podcast. Now you know everything about the new French President. Thank you, everyone, for listening to this new episode. As usual, you can find the transcript on my website.

[00:32:12] Next week, we'll talk about foreign languages. We'll see how knowing foreign languages influences our personality.

[00:32:26] Have a good week, and see you soon!